

Advertisement

TRANSPORTATION



Federal regulators give Zoox an exemption for its custom-built robotaxis



The National Highway Traffic Safety Administration has given Zoox an exemption to demonstrate its custom-built robotaxis on public roads and closed a related investigation into whether the Amazon-owned company had sidestepped federal regulations.

The decision, which was announced Wednesday, clears up a long-standing debate over whether Zoox's custom-built autonomous vehicles complied with federal motor vehicle safety standards, which place requirements on vehicles such as having a steering wheel and pedals. Zoox had argued that it did and announced in July 2022 that it had self-certified; NHTSA balked. The agency opened an investigation in March 2023 to look into the matter, and specifically the process and data that Zoox had used to self-certify.

The investigation didn't slow Zoox's development and testing of its autonomous vehicle technology. In early 2023, Zoox began [testing its custom-built robotaxis](#), which don't have a steering wheel or other traditional controls, on public roads near its Foster City, California headquarters. The company has since expanded its testing footprint to [Las Vegas and San Francisco](#).

Zoox does not operate a commercial service yet. However, in San Francisco it has opened its robotaxis up to employees and hosted family and friends. Earlier this year, the company launched an

TC DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

[Book Your Table >](#)

Most Popular



- Key sections of the US Constitution deleted from government's website
- Three weeks after acquiring Windsurf, Cognition offers staff the exit door
- Roku launches Howdy, a \$2.99 ad-free streaming service
- Spotify raises subscription prices
- The uproar over Vogue's AI-generated ad isn't just about fashion

Zoox Explorer program, aimed at early public riders, in Las Vegas.

For now, the exemption allows Zoox to demonstrate the robotaxis, not operate them commercially.

NHTSA's announcement is connected to its [new national framework](#), which the agency argues will make it easier for companies to deploy autonomous vehicles without traditional manual driving controls — like steering wheels, pedals, and sideview mirrors — at scale.

The framework, [known as AV STEP](#) (or ADS-Equipped Vehicle Safety, Transparency and Evaluation Program), allows NHTSA to green-light the sale and commercialization of autonomous vehicles that are not compliant with federal safety standards due to a lack of manual controls.

- Lina Khan points to Figma IPO as vindication of M&A scrutiny
- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

The revised process involves an expedited application that allows companies like Zoox to receive exemptions for testing and demonstrations,

and eventually, commercial operations. Zoox spokesperson Whitney Jencks said in an email that Zoox is working in close cooperation with NHTSA on this process, beginning with the demonstration exemption and followed by the commercial exemption.

As part of the agreement, NHTSA has closed its investigation into Zoox's self-certification of its AVs. Zoox has agreed to remove or cover all statements that its purpose-built vehicles comply with applicable Federal Motor Vehicle Safety Standards.

Topics: [autonomous vehicles](#) [Transportation](#) [zoox](#)



Kirsten Korosec

Transportation Editor |

Kirsten Korosec is a reporter and editor who has covered the future of transportation from EVs and autonomous...

[View Bio](#) >

———— KEEP READING ————

TRANSPORTATION





Zoox robotaxis start rolling out on California public roads

Kirsten Korosec — 10:00 AM PST · February 13, 2023

More than two years ago, Amazon subsidiary Zoox unveiled an [electric, autonomous robotaxi](#) it built from the ground up. Now, the cube-like vehicle that is loaded with sensors — and not a steering wheel — is starting to roll out on a few public roads in northern California.

A solitary Zoox robotaxi made its inaugural launch on public roads over the weekend after the company received a permit from the California Department of Motor Vehicles, the agency that regulates autonomous vehicles in the state. Zoox said the vehicle has also passed a self-certification from the Federal Motor Vehicle Safety Standards.

The scope of Zoox's launch on public roads is limited; however, it does mark another milestone for a company that launched quietly eight years ago with an ambitious goal to build and operate a commercial robotaxi service with its own purpose-built vehicle. The company has been testing its custom robotaxi vehicles on [“semi-private courses”](#) in California since last year. This weekend was the first time the vehicle carried passengers on public roads.

Newsletters

[See More ↗](#)

Subscribe for the industry's biggest tech news

TechCrunch Daily News



Every weekday and Sunday, you can get the best of TechCrunch's coverage.

Startups Weekly



Startups are the core of TechCrunch, so get our best coverage delivered weekly.

TechCrunch Week in Review



Get the best of our coverage, delivered to your inbox every Saturday.

TechCrunch Mobility



TechCrunch Mobility is your destination for transportation news and insight.

No newsletters selected.

Initially, robotaxis will only be available to Zoox employees and run as a shuttle service on about a two-mile loop between the company's two main buildings in Foster City, California.

"That sounds simple, but it's not. It's a very complex route," CEO Aicha Evans said in a news briefing with media. She noted that the route will include right-hand and left-hand turns, several traffic lights, pedestrians, bicyclists, as well as navigating in a parking lot and making bi-directional turns, which the robotaxi is designed to carry out.

The employee shuttle service is launching in the spring. Zoox did not disclose the size of the shuttle fleet. Zoox co-founder and CTO Jesse Levinson said the company has built dozens (not hundreds) of robotaxis and plans to add more of the vehicles to its permit with the DMV in the coming days.

It has been assumed that Zoox robotaxis would need an exemption from the federal government under FMVSS because the vehicles don't include traditional driving controls such as a steering wheel or pedals. Nuro, another AV company focused on delivery, [received an exemption](#) in early 2020 for its low-speed R2 vehicle.

Email address

Subscribe

By submitting your email, you agree to our [Terms](#) and [Privacy Notice](#).

TC

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

REGISTER NOW

But Zoox has [insisted for months](#) that an exemption isn't needed because it has incorporated FMVSS performance requirements into the vehicle.

The company didn't disclose when its employee service might expand to incorporate more roads or members of the public.

"You can assume that at some point after the spring we'll be able to put other folks in the vehicle, but we don't have a specific date," Levinson said. We will need additional permits to put non Zoox employees in our vehicles on public roads."

Zoox currently tests Toyota Highlander vehicles equipped with its self-driving system on public roads San Francisco, Las Vegas, Foster City, California (near its headquarters) and Seattle.

Topics: [Amazon](#) [autonomous vehicles](#) [robotaxi](#)

[Transportation](#) [transportation](#) [zoox](#)



Kirsten Korosec

Transportation Editor |

Kirsten Korosec is a reporter and editor who has covered the future of transportation from EVs and autonomous...

[View Bio](#) >

Latest

Security

Startups

AI

[Events](#)[Podcasts](#)[Newsletters](#)

IMAGE CREDITS: SEAN O'KANE

AMAZON-OWNED ZOOX issues recall following robotaxi crash

Kirsten Korosec — 12:06 PM PDT · May 6, 2025

Zoox, the autonomous vehicle company owned by Amazon, paused its driverless testing program for more than a week and issued a voluntary recall of its software following a crash in Las Vegas, according to the company and a filing with federal safety regulators.

The April 8 crash, which involved an unoccupied Zoox vehicle and a passenger car, prompted the company to issue a recall for about 270 vehicles equipped with a specific version of its automated driving system. The recall number doesn't reflect the full fleet size, according to Zoox. The recall was issued over concerns the self-driving software

Latest in Transportation

[See More](#)

TRANSPORTATION



Federal regulators give Zoox an exemption for its custom-built robotaxis

Kirsten Korosec - 13 hours ago

TRANSPORTATION



Jeh Aerospace nets \$11M to scale the commercial aircraft supply chain in India

could inaccurately predict the movement of another vehicle and increase the risk of a crash.

The company said no injuries were reported and minor damage occurred to both vehicles. The crash occurred after a passenger car quickly approached the lane from a commercial driveway where the purpose-built robotaxi was traveling, [according to Zoox](#). The Zoox vehicle, which inaccurately predicted that the passenger car would proceed, slowed down and steered to the right. Instead, “the car came to a stop, fully yielding to the Zoox robotaxi and remaining in the shoulder lane,” according to the company. “The Zoox robotaxi braked hard, but contact was unavoidable,” the company wrote in its blog post.

Zoox said it paused all driverless testing operations on April 8 — the day of the crash — and launched an internal review. Operations resumed after a software update was released to all Zoox vehicles on April 17, according to a [report submitted](#) to the National Highway Traffic Safety Administration.

The crash, and voluntary recall, comes as Zoox pushes to launch a commercial robotaxi service in Las Vegas. A company spokesperson confirmed that Zoox is still planning to launch that service later this year.

The company has been testing its self-driving system in retrofitted Toyota Highlanders and its custom-built robotaxis, which don’t have a steering wheel or pedals in various cities, notably along the Las Vegas Strip and in certain San Francisco neighborhoods. Earlier this year, Zoox allowed employees, media, and other vetted guests to [try the service](#). The company is also testing in Austin, Miami, and Seattle using Highlanders with human safety operators behind the wheel.

TRANSPORTATION



Foxconn sells former GM factory to mystery buyer after failing to make EVs

Sean O'Kane - 3 days ago

This is the second Zoox recall this year. In March, the company [issued a voluntary recall](#) for 258 vehicles due to issues with its autonomous driving system that could cause unexpected hard braking.

Last year, the NHTSA conducted a [preliminary investigation](#) into the company after the agency received two reports of incidents in which motorcyclists collided with the back of Toyota Highlanders equipped with Zoox technology. The initial investigation found that in both cases, the Zoox vehicles were operating with their autonomous systems engaged.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

Topics: [autonomous vehicles](#) [robotaxis](#) [Transportation](#)

[ZOOX](#)





Kirsten Korosec

Transportation Editor |

Kirsten Korosec is a reporter and editor who has covered the future of transportation from EVs and autonomous...

[View Bio](#) >

KEEP READING

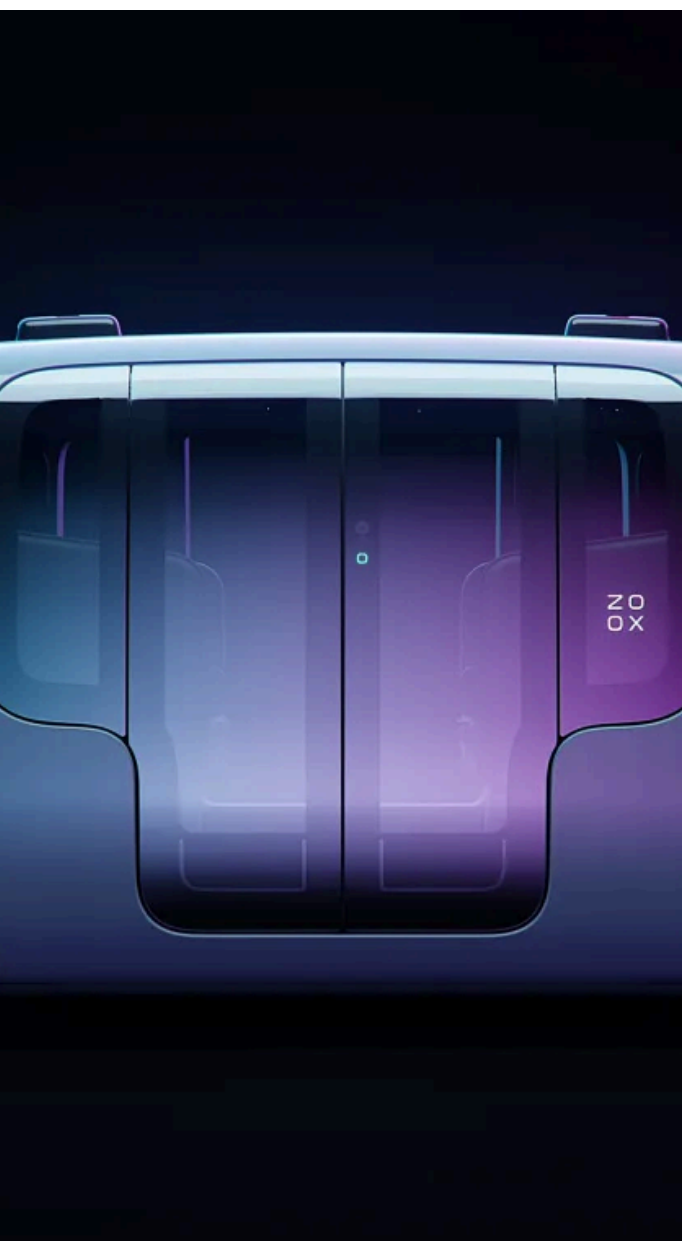


IMAGE CREDITS: ZOOX

Amazon's Zoox unveils electric robotaxi that can travel up to 75 mph

Kirsten Korosec — 7:30 AM PST · December 14, 2020

Six years ago, Zoox launched quietly with a mighty mission: build and commercialize just about every aspect of a robotaxi service from the self-driving software stack and on-demand ridesharing app to

DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

the management of the fleet and an unconventional vehicle that would transport passengers.

Now, it's finally lifting the veil on its multi-year effort. Zoox, which was acquired earlier this year by Amazon, unveiled the electric, autonomous robotaxi it built from the ground up — a cube-like vehicle loaded with sensors, no steering wheel and a moonroof that is capable of transporting four people at speeds of up to 75 miles per hour. The vehicle can drive bidirectionally and has four-wheel steering, capabilities that Zoox said were included to allow it to maneuver through compact spaces and change directions without the need to reverse. In other words, dense urban environments.

The vehicle has a four-seat, face-to-face symmetrical seating configuration, similar to what a train traveler might encounter. It's also equipped with a 133 kilowatt-hour battery that Zoox said allows it to operate for up to 16 continuous hours on a single charge. Zoox didn't provide a mileage range for the battery.

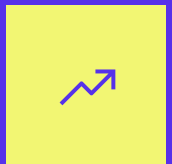
[Amazon to acquire autonomous driving startup Zoox](#)

There are other design goodies packed in and around the vehicle, including an airbag system for bidirectional vehicles and carriage seating that envelops passengers. Zoox said this is equal to five-star crash safety protections for all four seats. The vehicle has cameras, radar and lidar that gives it a 270-degree field of view on all four corners of the vehicle, which Zoox said lets it consistently track objects next to and behind it, including pedestrians, bicyclists and other road users.

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

[Book Your Table >](#)

Most Popular



- Key sections of the US Constitution deleted from government's website
- Three weeks after acquiring Windsurf, Cognition offers staff the exit door
- Roku launches Howdy, a \$2.99 ad-free streaming service
- Spotify raises subscription prices
- The uproar over Vogue's AI-generated ad isn't just about fashion
- Lina Khan points to Figma IPO as vindication of M&A scrutiny
- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines



ZOOX L5 FULLY AUTONOMOUS, ALL-ELECTRIC ROBOTAXI INTERIOR.
IMAGE: ZOOX

Zoox CTO Jesse Levinson said building the vehicle from the ground up gave the company an opportunity to reimagine passenger safety, shifting from reactive to proactive measures. “These include new safety features such as our airbag design, redundant hardware throughout the vehicle, a unique sensor architecture, and a custom AI stack that detects and mitigates potential risks,” Levinson said, adding that the vehicle has passed key Federal Motor Vehicle Safety Standards crash tests.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

[REGISTER NOW](#)

What is not yet known is if Zoox has received approval by the FMVSS to operate the vehicle. These federal standards require manufacturers to build vehicles with specific features such as steering wheels. The Zoox vehicle doesn't have one since it was designed to drive on its own. Earlier this year, autonomous delivery startup Nuro became the first company to receive a driverless exemption from the federal government.

The exemption granted by the the U.S. Department of Transportation's National Highway Traffic Safety Administration is for Nuro's new low-speed electric vehicle called the R2 that will be used for local delivery service for restaurants, grocery stores and other businesses. While Nuro's vehicle doesn't have a steering wheel either, it's also designed just for delivering goods, not people.

[Zoox becomes fourth company to land driverless testing permit in California](#)

Despite this final and important regulatory hurdle, completing the vehicle is a milestone for the company. Zoox CEO Aicha Evans said it marks an important step on the company's journey toward deploying an autonomous ride-hailing service.

Zoox is testing the purpose-built vehicle on private roads, and will then move to public roads, the company said in an email exchange. "This is an important step, as Zoox wants to ensure that the vehicles on the road have been thoroughly tested, vetted, and are ready for the public to use," the spokesperson said in the email. "Zoox is still on our journey on the path of launching a commercial ride-hailing service."

Zoox, which operates as an independent subsidiary of Amazon, is currently testing in Las Vegas, San Francisco and Foster City. The company intends to handle all aspects of the robotaxi service and could

eventually expand to delivering packages,
according to an interview Evans had with
[Bloomberg](#).



Zoox Fully Autonomous, All-electric Robotaxi

Zoox L5 Fully Autonomous, All-electric Robotaxi

Zoox Fully Autonomous, All-electric Robotaxi

Zoox Fully Autonomous, All-electric Robotaxi

Zoox Fully Autonomous, All-electric Robotaxi

Zoox Fully Autonomous, All-electric Robotaxi

Zoox Fully Autonomous, All-electric Robotaxi

Zoox L5 Fully Autonomous, All-electric Robotaxi

Zoox L5 Fully Autonomous, All-electric Robotaxi
Interior

Zoox Fully Autonomous, All-electric Robotaxi

Zoox Fully Autonomous, All-electric Robotaxi

Zoox L5 Fully Autonomous, All-electric Robotaxi

Topics: [Amazon](#) [autonomous vehicles](#)

[electric vehicles](#) [robotaxi](#) [Transportation](#)

[ZOOX](#)

Advertisement



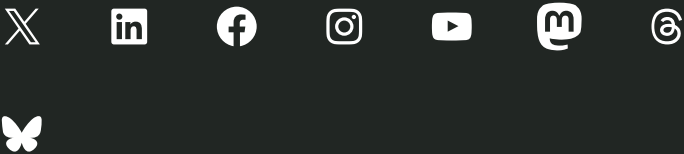
Kirsten Korosec

Transportation Editor | [X](#) [f](#) [in](#)

Kirsten Korosec is a reporter and editor who has covered the future of transportation from EVs and autonomous...

View Bio >

Loading the next article



TechCrunch
Staff
Contact Us
Advertise
Crunchboard
Jobs
Site Map

Terms of
Service
Privacy
Policy
RSS Terms of
Use

OpenAI
Perplexity
Cisco
DeepMind
Windsurf
Tech Layoffs
ChatGPT